Using CSS and React Components

Where Stimulus encourages using the markup you are already writing, therefore keeping CSS in its own separate files, React encourages thinking about CSS and code together. Once you get in the habit of thinking of your page as made up of a number of different React components, it's only a small step to imagine those components as containing their own CSS for features that are specific to that component.

Including CSS with React code is such a common thought that there are oodles of libraries that handle this. I'm going to talk about one of these libraries that has an interesting way to insert CSS into your React code: styled-components.

What Is the styled-components Library?

The styled-components library allows you to define React components that include CSS styles inside the definition of the component.[46] When the component renders, the styled-components library generates CSS code with definitions for these styles and uses those generated CSS class names in the rendered HTML markup.

In practice, what this means is that we are not attaching CSS definitions to the React components we've already defined. Instead the internal markup of the components, such as `div` and `span` tags, is replaced with styled-components that contain their own CSS.

Why would you do such a thing? Isn't CSS good enough? CSS is great. However, there are a few reasons why it's helpful to bundle CSS with React components:

- It's easier to see what CSS applies to a component because the styling is right there in the same file as the component.
- There tends to be a better separation of styling from logic, and as a result, the logic components tend to be a little cleaner.